

of us were deprived of any sort of human touch entirely. There was nobody even to hold us through such a strange and disorientating time. We were living through a collective trauma, and we were grieving for life as we knew it, and nothing was the same.

There was one thing, though. A guaranteed dopamine hit that you only needed a smartphone, tablet or laptop to access. Online shopping. The double-high of the checkout button and doorbell ring made spending online one of the only crutches for many people, and all of those gains from earlier in the year quickly ebbed away. I wrote about this phenomenon for Refinery29, interviewing a brilliant psychologist, Dr Eleanor Seddon, who probably did more for my understanding of spending habits in a few minutes than I had gained from months of self-examination. Dr Seddon explained to me about the soothing systems that we all have in place to help us to cope with strong or difficult emotions and make us feel safe, but also about the limitations that those soothing systems have when combined with our fast-paced consumer culture.

‘The problem is that our brain is hard-wired to take decisions that benefit us in the short term but may make the problem worse in the long run. Emotional spending provides an immediate sense of wellbeing. The dopamine hit of “treating yourself” is a quick way to feel better without considering the consequences that may actually make our mood worse,’ she says.